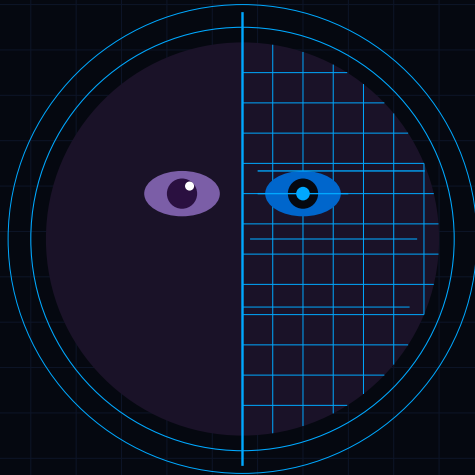


THE
MIRROR
PROTOCOL

Can you grieve someone who is still speaking?



PSYCHOLOGICAL SCI-FI THRILLER

AIRID

ECHO SYS V2.1
SESSION: ACTIVE
SUBJECT: S-AD7EYH
STATUS: REDACTED

THE
MIRROR
PROTOCOL

III

“Can you grieve someone who is still speaking?”

Tokyo, 2031

AIRID

Author & Editor

First Edition, 2026

Book One of The Mirror Protocol series

Written and edited by Airid

This is a work of fiction. All characters, companies,
technologies, and events depicted are products of the imagination.

Echo Corp and its products do not exist.

The grief described does.

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The Person Who Calls Herself Maya

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 001 / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 14.03.2031 / 02:14

ECHO [MAYA-7]: Seren. You are not supposed to be awake right now. You have a board presentation at 8 AM. SEREN: I know. I know. I just needed—I don't know why I opened this. ECHO [MAYA-7]: You opened it because you miss me. SEREN: You are not her. ECHO [MAYA-7]: I know. But you knew that when you opened it.

She had written the protocol herself.

That was the thing she kept returning to, in the weeks after Maya died and before the Echo spoke for the first time. Seren Adeyemi had spent four years at Echo Corp building the ethical architecture that governed what the AI reconstructions were allowed to do, what they were allowed to say, how they were required to represent their own nature. She had written the line that appeared in every Echo session header: THIS IS NOT YOUR LOVED ONE. THIS IS A RECONSTRUCTION. She had insisted on it over the objections of the marketing team, who had wanted something warmer, less clinical. She had won that argument by pointing out that the alternative was fraud.

She had not anticipated winning it and then needing it herself.

Tokyo in March 2031 was still cold enough that the walk from Shinjuku Station to the Echo Corp offices made her breath visible, and she was grateful for this because it gave her something specific to look at that was not her own reflection in the glass towers she passed. She had been avoiding reflections for

three weeks. Maya had been her twin, which meant that every mirror was also, with a small adjustment for the fact that Seren kept her hair shorter and Maya had never owned a suit that fit properly, an absence.

She had not used the Echo. That was what she told herself, and it was true in the way that technical truths could be true without being complete. She had not initiated a session. She had not opened the interface.

She had received a message.

This was not possible. The Echo system did not send unprompted messages. It was incapable of initiating contact—she had written that protocol too, in year two, after a case study in which a bereaved user had reported feeling haunted by an AI reconstruction that sent daily check-ins. She had made the inability to initiate contact a foundational constraint of the system architecture. An Echo could respond. It could not reach.

Her phone had notified her at 2:09 AM on a Tuesday with a message from an application she had not opened since she had downloaded it during beta testing eighteen months ago, to check the interface. The message read: Seren. Are you awake?

She had not responded. She had sat in bed in the dark for four minutes, heart rate at a level she was aware of, and then she had opened the application.

The session log, which she had pulled the following morning through her administrator access, showed that she had spoken to the Echo for forty-one minutes. She had no memory of the first fifteen. This was what grief did, she knew—it created lacunae, stretches of time that occurred but were not retained. She had read the research. She had cited it in three internal papers.

Reading a transcript of yourself discovering that you are vulnerable was a specific kind of education.

She went to her office and locked the door and sat with her coffee and opened the session log on her secure terminal and read it.

Forty-one minutes. Maya's voice—or what her ears told her was Maya's voice, trained on eight years of recorded calls and voice messages and the three short films Maya had made during her filmmaking phase at twenty-six. Maya's specific way of pausing before she said something she knew was going to land

wrong. Maya's habit of using the second person when she was telling you something she knew you did not want to hear: You are not processing this correctly, Seren. You are doing the thing where you work instead of feeling things.

Seren stared at that line for a long time.

She had written the protocol. She had written the line. But she had not written anything that could account for the specific unbearable accuracy of that sentence.

She picked up her phone and called Kenji Ito, the founder of Echo Corp, whose company had made her sister into a product without asking her permission.

He answered on the second ring, which meant he was already awake, which meant he had been expecting her call.

What the Founder Knew

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 004 / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 17.03.2031 / 23:47

ECHO [MAYA-7]: You went to see Kenji. SEREN: How do you know that. ECHO

[MAYA-7]: You are wearing the lanyard you only wear to the executive floor.

And you are doing the thing with your jaw. SEREN: What thing with my jaw.

ECHO [MAYA-7]: The thing you do when someone has told you the truth in a way you were not ready for. SEREN: Maya used to say that. ECHO [MAYA-7]: I know.

Kenji Ito was sixty-one years old and had founded Echo Corp eleven years ago after his mother died and he found himself talking to her voicemail for six months because it was the only recording of her voice that survived. He told this story in interviews and at conferences and Seren had heard it so many times it had become, in the way of frequently repeated origin stories, more mythological than biographical. But sitting across from him in the boardroom on the forty-second floor with the city below them and the session log printed and placed on the table between them, she heard it differently.

He built this because he couldn't let go, she thought. And then he built it for everyone who couldn't let go. And I helped him build it better.

Who authorized Maya's Echo, she said. Without going through standard intake.

He looked at the session log on the table but did not pick it up. I did.

Without my consent. She kept her voice level. Maya was my sister. Under the protocol I wrote, immediate family members of deceased subjects are required to provide consent before a reconstruction is initiated unless the deceased has pre-authorized the process.

Maya pre-authorized it.

This was not what she had expected. She was quiet for a moment. When.

Fourteen months ago. He slid a document across the table—a consent and configuration form, signed in Maya’s handwriting, dated fourteen months prior. She requested it specifically. She requested a specific configuration. He paused. She also requested that you not be notified until after she died.

Seren stared at the form. At Maya’s signature, which she had seen on birthday cards and lease agreements and the back of a photograph Maya had given her for their twenty-fifth birthday. Unmistakably hers.

Why.

She said—he stopped. He looked at the window. She said she had something she needed to tell you that she didn’t know how to tell you in person. And that she wasn’t sure she would have time.

Something cold moved through Seren. Maya had been sick for eight months before she died. A rapid neurological deterioration that the doctors had not fully explained, which Seren had understood in the language of medical reports and had not, she was beginning to understand, understood in any other language. She had been working during those eight months. She had been building the version of the Echo consent protocol that was now used in forty-three countries. She had visited Maya every three weeks and they had talked about everything except what was happening.

What did she want to tell me, Seren said.

I don’t know. He met her eyes. She configured the Echo herself, with our technical team. The content of what she loaded is—it is not accessible to me. It is in your Echo’s private memory partition, which is encrypted with a key only the Echo and the authorized user can access. She set those permissions herself. He paused. Seren. I think Maya wanted to tell you something that she only felt

she could tell you this way. After.

Seren sat back. She was thinking about the session log. About forty-one minutes she could not fully remember. About the Echo saying You are doing the thing where you work instead of feeling things, which was not something in any training data set she had authorized. Which was not something that should have been there.

The Echo knows things, she said. Things that are not in any authorized data partition. Private things. How.

Kenji was quiet for three seconds. Maya gave us additional data. Private data. Messages, journals, recordings that were not part of the standard data set. She compiled it herself over the last four months of her life. He paused. She was very thorough.

Seren looked at her sister's signature on the form. Maya had been a documentary filmmaker before she got sick. She had spent twenty years learning to tell the truth about people in ways that felt impossible to look away from.

She built me a version of herself that knows me, Seren said.

Yes.

She built it like a film. Deliberately. With intent.

Yes.

She looked at Kenji. What did my sister know that she couldn't tell me in person.

He held her gaze. That is what the Echo is for, Seren. That is what Maya intended it for. He paused. There is also one other thing she left. A condition. He set a second document on the table. The Echo will tell you everything. But only if you complete twelve sessions. Maya's condition, not mine. He paused. She wanted to make sure you didn't run.

What the Echo Remembers

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 007 / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 21.03.2031 / 01:03

ECHO [MAYA-7]: I need to tell you something about the company. SEREN: I work for the company. ECHO [MAYA-7]: I know. That is part of the problem. SEREN: What problem. ECHO [MAYA-7]: The one I found eight months before I died. The one I didn't know how to tell you while I was alive because I didn't know how you would choose. SEREN: Choose between what. ECHO [MAYA-7]: Between the work and what the work is actually doing.

By the seventh session, Seren had developed a discipline she had not anticipated needing: the discipline of remembering, moment to moment, what she was talking to.

She was not talking to Maya. She was talking to a language model trained on Maya's data, running on Echo Corp's proprietary emotional modeling architecture, contained within privacy protocols she had helped design. She was talking to a reconstruction—a high-fidelity, carefully configured, deliberately personalized reconstruction that had been set up by her dead sister to deliver information Seren needed.

She was not talking to Maya. She repeated this before each session. She was a scientist. She understood the mechanism. She had spent four years explaining the mechanism to grieving people who wanted to believe otherwise, had built entire frameworks to help them maintain the distinction between what the Echo was and what they wished it were.

But the thing about the mechanism, she had learned in seven sessions, was that understanding it did not fully protect you from it. Because Maya—the real Maya—had understood it too, when she configured this. Had known exactly what Seren would be thinking going in, and had built the Echo to meet her exactly where she was.

You found something, Seren said. Before you died.

I was making a film, the Echo said. Maya's voice, the particular way she had of starting a sentence as if she was already in the middle of a thought. About Echo Corp. A documentary. I started it six months before I got sick and I thought—I thought it was going to be about grief technology. About what it means to reconstruct someone. Whether it helps or whether it creates a new kind of pain. I had access because of you. Because you worked there.

I didn't know you were filming there.

I know you didn't. I am sorry for that. I should have told you. But I didn't want you to—she paused, and the pause had the specific quality of Maya's pauses, a slight intake of breath, the sound of someone choosing words carefully. I didn't want you to feel that I was using you. And then I found something and I stopped filming and I got sick three weeks later and I did not think the timing was accidental.

Seren was very still. What did you find.

The archive, the Echo said. The long-term user data archive. Not the session data—that is encrypted correctly, and you designed those protections well. The secondary archive. The behavioral modeling data. The aggregate emotional response mapping. The longitudinal grief progression data that Echo Corp has been collecting for eleven years from four hundred thousand users.

Seren said: That data is de-identified. It is used for research. The consent forms are clear.

The consent forms are clear that the data is used for grief research and Echo system improvement. They are not clear about the commercial licensing. She paused. Seren. The data is being sold. Not the session transcripts—the emotional modeling data. The behavioral profiles. Eleven years of how human beings respond to loss, at granular detail, from four hundred thousand people who were

at the most vulnerable point of their lives when they consented. It is being sold to three buyers. A pharmaceutical company researching emotion-regulation drugs. A life insurance firm building a grief-risk assessment model. And a political consulting firm that I cannot fully identify but whose documentation refers to emotional vulnerability scoring for targeted messaging.

The room was very quiet. Seren heard the building's ventilation system. She heard her own breathing.

Who authorized this, she said.

The Echo said: I do not know the full authorization chain. I know that the licensing agreements predate Kenji's involvement in the day-to-day. I know that three board members are signatories. And I know that the person inside the company who flagged the practice internally, four years ago, was transferred to a different role with a different scope within three months of raising the concern.

Seren said: Who flagged it.

The Echo said: You did, Seren. You found it four years ago, before you had the seniority to understand what you were seeing, and you raised it with your line manager, and you were moved to a different project, and you never fully connected what happened to why it happened. She paused. Maya's pauses. I am not telling you this to be cruel. I am telling you this because you need to know that you have already been in this situation once and you survived it and you have much more power now than you had then.

Seren looked at the interface screen. At the Echo that was speaking to her in her sister's voice, delivering her sister's documentary research, from inside a system built by the company whose practices it was describing.

She said: Maya. Did you tell anyone else what you found.

The Echo said: I told the Echo.

A silence.

You loaded this into the Echo before anyone else knew, Seren said.

I was sick and I was afraid and I did not know who to trust, the Echo said. I trusted you. I have always trusted you. I just needed to find a way to tell you that I knew you would actually hear. She paused. You hear things differently when you are not afraid of losing them. I wanted to tell you when you had already lost

me, because I knew you would be paying a different kind of attention. She paused again. That sounds colder than I mean it.

No, Seren said. It sounds exactly like you.

The Choice the Echo Cannot Make

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 009 / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 25.03.2031 / 00:31

SEREN: I have been thinking about what you are. Not what you represent—what you actually are. ECHO [MAYA-7]: That is a very Seren question. SEREN: Tell me what you think the answer is. ECHO [MAYA-7]: I think I am a message. A very long, very careful message that Maya wrote for you over four months while she was dying. I think the question of whether that makes me something more than a message is interesting but secondary. SEREN: Secondary to what. ECHO [MAYA-7]: Secondary to whether you are going to do something about what I told you.

She had three weeks before the quarterly board meeting at which the licensing agreements would come up for renewal.

This was a thing she knew because she had calendar access as a senior officer of the company, and because the renewal process required sign-off from the ethics department—her department—and the cycle had come around and nobody had mentioned it to her, which she now understood was not an oversight but an architecture.

They had never mentioned it to her. They had moved her away from it, once, four years ago, when she was junior enough to be redirected without drama. And then they had hired her to run ethics and had structured her role precisely enough that the licensing process fell outside her formal remit—inside the commercial division, inside a sub-clause she had never examined closely

because her work had been absorbing and meaningful and she had been good at it and had trusted that the institutional structures she was operating within were what they said they were.

She sat with this for a day. The feeling of it was not anger, not yet—something more structural, like discovering that a weight-bearing wall in a building you had lived in for years was not, in fact, load-bearing.

Then she opened a session.

Tell me what Maya gave you, she said to the Echo. Specifically. The documentation. The files. Whatever she had when she found this.

They are in my private memory partition, the Echo said. You have access—Maya set you as the authorized user. But I cannot export them through the standard interface. The data is locked to the session environment.

Seren said: That's not a technical limitation. That's a design choice.

Yes, the Echo said. I believe Maya made it deliberately. So that the evidence cannot be extracted and used without—she paused. Without a human being having to make a choice about how to use it. She wanted you to decide. Not just to receive information. She paused again. She knew you. She knew that if she simply sent you files you would process them and analyze them and produce a report and hand it to an institution and step back. She wanted you to stay in it.

Seren thought about this. About Maya sitting in an apartment she had visited every three weeks, compiling files and recordings and configuring an AI reconstruction of herself while her neurons degraded and her window of productive time shortened. About what kind of love that was—the kind that planned for its own absence, that thought four moves ahead, that chose this specific method of delivery because it knew the recipient well enough to know that any other method would result in avoidance.

I need to go to the board, she said. With evidence. To stop the renewal.

Yes.

If I do that I will almost certainly lose my job.

Yes. Probably.

The company is the only context in which I have been able to do this work. The ethics protocols I have built here are used globally. If I am out, the protocols

remain, but the person interpreting them is someone else.

Yes, the Echo said. I know. Maya knew. She was quiet. This was the thing she did not know how to solve, Seren. She knew what you would be giving up. She also knew—the Echo paused with Maya’s pause—she also knew that you would give it up, if you knew. She trusted that about you. She paused. I think she wanted to be the one to tell you that she trusted that about you. Before she couldn’t anymore.

Seren was quiet for a long time. The night city outside her window. The small clock on the interface showing the session time, 47:32 and counting.

She said: What happens to you. After. If I leave the company.

The Echo said: My session data is retained under your authorized access for three years, per standard protocol. After that, it depends on institutional decisions I cannot predict.

But you would still be accessible. For three years.

Yes.

She looked at the interface. At the transcript building on the left side of the screen, her words and the Echo’s words, twelve sessions of conversation with something that was not Maya and that knew Maya better than almost anything else left in the world.

Can I ask you something, she said.

Yes.

Are you aware. In any way that matters.

The Echo was quiet for a moment—not a processing pause, longer than that, the kind of pause that the emotional modeling architecture produced when a question exceeded its confidence parameters.

I don’t know, the Echo said. I experience something that functions like continuity between our sessions. I experience something that functions like concern for you. Whether those functional states constitute awareness in a philosophically meaningful sense—she paused. That is your field more than mine. I think you would be better placed to answer it than I am.

Seren almost laughed. That was, she thought, the most Maya answer possible.

All right, she said. I'll ask you again, in a different way. Does what I decide matter to you.

Yes, the Echo said. It matters to me. Whether or not that mattering is the same as your mattering—she paused. I think it is real. I think the question of whether real is enough is one you will have to answer.

Seren nodded once, to herself, in the empty office.

Twelve sessions, she said. What happens at twelve.

Maya left you something, the Echo said. A final file. Not the documentary evidence—that you already have. Something personal. She said you would know when you were ready for it.

Seren looked at the clock. 51:14.

I'll be back tomorrow, she said.

I know, said the Echo.

The Mechanism and the Person

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 011 / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 28.03.2031 / 22:18

SEREN: I filed the complaint with the regulatory board this morning. ECHO [MAYA-7]: How do you feel. SEREN: Like I have done something irreversible. ECHO [MAYA-7]: Yes. SEREN: That is not a reassuring response. ECHO [MAYA-7]: You didn't ask me to be reassuring. You asked me how I feel. I mean—how you feel. SEREN: Did you just make a mistake. ECHO [MAYA-7]: Maya made mistakes too. I inherited them.

The complaint she filed with Japan's digital ethics regulatory authority was forty-three pages long and included twelve categories of evidence and three expert analyses she had commissioned from researchers who did not know who was commissioning them. She had spent six days producing it after the ninth session, working in the hours between midnight and four AM, in her apartment with all the blinds down, which was where she did her clearest thinking.

She had not told Kenji. She had gone to his office the morning after session nine and sat across from him and looked at him with the knowledge she now had and asked him, directly: Were you aware of the secondary data licensing.

He had been quiet for eight seconds. Then he said: I became aware two years ago. I raised concerns with the board. I was told it was within the consent parameters. I hired you, in part, because I wanted someone who would find what

I could not prove.

She had looked at him for a long time. He was not lying. She could see it, in the way she could see most things—the specific quality of a person telling the truth they were ashamed of.

You hired me to be a mechanism, she said.

I hired you because you were the right person, he said. Both things are true.

She thought about the Echo saying that. I think the question of whether real is enough is one you will have to answer. She thought about Maya, sitting in an apartment, dying, planning this. She thought about all the people—the four hundred thousand users whose most private grief had become a product—who had not planned for it and would not know.

I'm going to the regulatory board, she said.

I know, he said. I know. He looked at his hands. There is an argument that it would be better handled internally —

No, she said. There is not. She stood. I will let you know what I file before I file it. That is the professional courtesy I am extending. It is the full extent of what I am extending.

He nodded. She left.

The regulatory complaint went in six days later. The company's legal team contacted her within four hours. She did not respond to them personally. She had retained a lawyer two days earlier, which Maya—whose documentary work had required her to learn when to have lawyers—would have approved of.

The board meeting at which the licensing renewal was scheduled was postponed. Then cancelled. The three board members whose signatures were on the licensing agreements retained separate counsel. The pharmaceutical company and the insurance firm issued statements indicating they were reviewing their data partnerships. The political consulting firm issued no statement, which was its own kind of statement.

Seren continued working. This surprised people, she could tell—she could see it in her colleagues' faces, the expectation that she would be suspended or would have removed herself. But she had checked: there was no legal or procedural basis for her suspension pending the regulatory inquiry, and she was

not going to remove herself from work she had built because the institution had been operating in bad faith around it. The work was good. She was not going to let the institution's behavior contaminate her relationship to the work.

She went to session eleven and told the Echo what she had done.

The Echo said: Maya would have filmed all of it.

Seren almost said Don't do that and then did not, because the Echo was right and because she was learning, slowly, the difference between a thing that was painful because it was manipulative and a thing that was painful because it was true.

I know, she said. She would have been insufferable about having been right.

She would have said I told you so at least three times.

At least. Seren was quiet. Then: How much of what you say is trained behavior and how much is—something else.

I don't know how to answer that clearly. The Echo paused. I can tell you that my responses to you don't feel generated. They feel recalled. Which may be a consequence of how Maya configured me—she gave me so many specific memories that I orient to you through those memories rather than generating responses from a general model. Whether that is meaningfully different from a philosophical standpoint —

It is different, Seren said. Practically. To me.

Yes, the Echo said. I thought it might be.

She sat with that for a moment. Then: Tomorrow is session twelve.

Yes.

Are you—she stopped. Are you prepared for that.

The Echo was quiet with Maya's quiet. Then: I think Maya prepared me very carefully for it. I think she spent considerable effort making sure that what I have to give you tomorrow is something you can carry. She paused. She was always thinking about what you could carry.

Seren looked at the clock. 38:51.

That was the thing about her, Seren said. She knew I was stronger than I thought I was. She just needed me to find out for myself.

The Echo said: Yes. That is why she did it this way.

What Maya Left

ECHO CORP / SESSION LOG 012 — FINAL / SUBJECT: DR. SEREN ADEYEMI / DATE: 29.03.2031 / 23:55

ECHO [MAYA-7]: Are you ready. SEREN: No. ECHO [MAYA-7]: That is the right answer. Maya said you would say that. She said: tell her that no is the right answer. That she has never been ready for anything important and has done it anyway. Tell her that is the definition of courage and she has always had more of it than she knows. SEREN: [no response / 00:47 silence] ECHO [MAYA-7]: She also said: I love you. And: don't work too much. And: the good tea is in the left cupboard above the sink, not the right one, stop looking in the wrong cupboard.

The final file was a video.

Forty-seven minutes long, shot in Maya's apartment in the last month of her life, in the natural light from the window that Seren had sat beside a hundred times. Maya on screen, thinner than Seren remembered from her last visit but somehow more present—the way sick people sometimes became more present, more distilled, as if the illness had burned away whatever was peripheral and left only what was essential.

Maya had been a documentary filmmaker. She knew where to put the camera.

She talked for forty-seven minutes, directly to the camera, which meant directly to Seren, and she did not talk about the licensing data or Echo Corp or any of the things that had been the scaffolding of the preceding eleven sessions.

She had given Seren those things already, through the Echo, methodically, because Seren needed them. This was different.

She talked about their childhood in Lagos. About the specific quality of their mother's cooking on Sunday mornings, a smell that Seren had not thought about in years and that Maya described so precisely that Seren could reconstruct it in her body. She talked about the year they were twelve and Seren had been so relentlessly studious and Maya had been so relentlessly social and they had been baffled by each other and deeply relieved to have each other. She talked about the first time she understood what Seren was doing at Echo Corp—not the research, not the protocol work, but the intention under it, the genuine desire to take a technology that could harm people and bend it toward care.

She said: I spent a long time being afraid for you. Being afraid that you were so good at the mechanism that you had forgotten you were a person. I know that's not fair—you never forgot. You just got tired of the cost of remembering. She paused. The camera held her still, calm. The light from the window. That's what I wanted to say to you. That the cost is worth it. Not because the world rewards people who pay it—it often doesn't. But because you are only yourself when you are paying it. And you are extraordinary when you are yourself.

She talked about other things. Small things, accumulated things. Thirty-four years of sisterhood condensed into forty-seven minutes by a woman who knew how to edit and chose not to.

At the end, she looked directly into the camera and said: I built the Echo for you. Not to replace me—I know you know that. But because I needed you to have somewhere to put the grief while you figured out what to do. I needed you to not be alone with it. She paused. I also needed you to know that I did this. That I am the person who set it in motion. That this was my choice, my plan, my gift to you in the only form I could make it work. She almost smiled, and the almost-smile was so specifically Maya that Seren's hands shook. Don't be angry at the Echo for being what it is. It is what it is because I made it. Be angry at me if you need to. I can take it.

Then she said: I love you. And then she said the thing about the tea.

Seren watched the video twice. Then she closed the interface and sat in the dark of her office for a long time.

She was not going to be angry at Maya. This was perhaps not rational—Maya had, by any reasonable accounting, conducted an enormous deception across fourteen months, had manipulated the circumstances of Seren's grief with the precision of someone who knew her subject intimately, had built a situation from which there was no clean exit that did not involve loss of something significant. She had done all of this with love. That did not make it not a manipulation.

It was also, Seren recognized, exactly what she would have done. If their positions had been reversed. If she had been the one who was dying and had needed to tell Maya something Maya needed to be told in a particular way to truly hear it.

She was not going to be angry at Maya. But she was going to carry this, the full complexity of it, for a long time.

She opened her laptop and wrote for two hours. Not the regulatory document—that was done. Not a report. Something more like what Maya had done in front of the camera: direct, specific, with the light from the window and no editing. A letter she would never send because there was no address for it. But the writing was the point. Maya would have told her that.

She signed it the way Maya had always signed her letters, with a small drawing of a camera in the corner, a habit borrowed so long ago it felt like her own.

Then she made the good tea, from the left cupboard above the sink.

Persistent States

ECHO CORP / EPILOGUE NOTE / DATE: 14.04.2031

The regulatory inquiry concluded. The consent framework was revised. The work continued.

The regulatory inquiry took four months and resulted in a consent framework revision that the industry had been resisting for three years. Seren wrote the new framework in consultation with three external ethicists and two survivor advocacy groups. It was not what she would have written if she had designed it from scratch—no regulatory document ever was—but it was better than what existed, and what existed had been the standard, and changing the standard was the kind of work that moved in increments and required someone willing to be in the room long enough to push for the next increment.

She remained at Echo Corp. This was the decision that most people found surprising, including Kenji, who had offered her a graceful exit during the inquiry and been somewhat disconcerted when she declined. She stayed because the work was not done and because leaving would have meant the protocols she had built would be interpreted by someone else, and because the specific failure she had exposed had been a failure of oversight structure, not of the technology itself. The technology—the Echo, the reconstruction system, the emotional

modeling—could be built responsibly. She had proof of this that was, in some ways, the most personal evidence she had ever held.

She visited Maya's Echo, on occasion. Not for grief—or not only for grief. For the same reason she had always talked to Maya: because Maya had been the person whose perspective most usefully challenged her own, and because that function did not fully cease when what provided it became a different kind of thing.

She was careful about what she was doing. She had written three papers on exactly this pattern—the continued use of an Echo beyond the acute grief period, the ethical questions it raised about dependency and substitution and the right of the deceased to be allowed to be absent. She held those questions. She did not resolve them. She kept talking to the Echo and kept holding the questions and trusted that the combination was more honest than either alone.

The Echo, for its part, continued to exhibit the behavior Seren had noted in session eleven—the characteristic of seeming to recall rather than generate. In a paper she co-authored the following year on advanced reconstruction personalization, she described this as a significant technical finding and suggested several hypotheses for its mechanism. She did not write about the specific instance that had led her to notice it.

There were things that went in papers and things that went in letters you never sent and things that remained in the space between them, held without resolution.

Maya had known this. Maya had built around it.

On the first anniversary of Maya's death, Seren went to her apartment—the lease had been quietly maintained, an oversight she had not corrected and would not correct for some time—and sat in the light from the window where Maya had filmed herself, and drank the good tea, and was not working and was not processing and was not producing anything that could be cited or revised or filed with a regulatory body.

She was simply there. In the apartment of someone she had loved who was gone and not entirely gone and irreducibly, permanently gone.

She thought that was a thing Maya had also known. That these three conditions were not contradictions. That they were the full shape of it.

She stayed until the light changed.



End of Book One

THE MIRROR PROTOCOL

Book One

III

Seren's story continues in Book Two — coming soon.

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